

The Single-Source Condition for Coherent Intelligence

~The Condition for Intelligence Itself

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Abstract

Most contemporary accounts of intelligence define it in terms of capability, performance, or optimization. These approaches do not specify the structural condition under which an intelligence remains non-contradictory across time, context, and domain.

This paper proposes that coherence in intelligence requires a single, non-contradictory generative causal source. When action is generated from a plural causal basis, the system becomes intrinsically unstable and must rely on arbitration, trade-off, and context-dependent reversal. By contrast, when action is derived from a single invariant, contradiction is not managed but rendered non-admissible.

This paper defines coherence as a structural property, distinguishes plural and single-source generative forms, identifies behavioral indicators of each, and considers the implications for biological, artificial, and institutional intelligence. The single-source condition is presented as a necessary architectural requirement for coherent intelligence.

1. Introduction

Intelligence is commonly described in terms of what it can do: solve problems, model environments, optimize outcomes, or adapt to change. These descriptions focus on capacity and performance. They do not address the structural condition under which an intelligence remains the same intelligence across time and circumstance.

Yet incoherence in intelligence is immediately recognizable. It appears when a system:

- produces mutually incompatible actions from the same knowledge state
- reverses its conclusions without the introduction of new information
- requires internal negotiation between its own primary outputs.

These are not simply errors. They are indicators of a generative structure that cannot maintain continuity.

This paper proposes that the stability of intelligence is not primarily a function of capability but of causal form. Coherent intelligence requires that action be generated from a single non-contradictory causal source. Where the generative basis is plural, instability is intrinsic.

2. Coherence as a Structural Property

In this paper, coherence does not mean agreement, harmony, or social alignment. It refers to a structural condition:

An intelligence is coherent when it does not generate mutually incompatible actions from the same knowledge state.

Incoherence is therefore not defined by disagreement with an external standard but by internal contradiction.

This definition is domain-neutral and behaviorally observable.

A coherent intelligence:

- maintains continuity of action across contexts
- does not require arbitration between its own primary outputs
- changes its conclusions only when its knowledge state changes.

An incoherent intelligence:

- must negotiate between competing internal directives
 - exhibits policy drift
 - produces context-dependent reversals.
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3. Generative Causation

Every intelligence acts from a generative basis. This basis is not the set of all influences on the system but the primary source from which action is derived.

Two structural forms are possible.

3.1 Plural generative structure

Action is produced through the interaction of multiple primary causes.

Because these causes are not derivable from one another, action requires:

- prioritization
- weighting
- trade-off
- or contextual arbitration.

3.2 Single-source generation

Action is derived from a single invariant that is internally non-contradictory.

In this form:

- action is not negotiated
 - contradiction is not resolved but disallowed
 - continuity is preserved.
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4. Instability of Plural Generative Systems

Where the generative basis is plural, instability is structural rather than accidental.

Plural systems must continually answer the question:

Which primary directive governs this action?

Because the directives are not reducible to one another, this decision cannot be final. It must be made again in each new context.

The result is:

- policy drift
- context sensitivity of core behavior
- the production of mutually incompatible outputs from the same knowledge state.

These are not failures of implementation. They are the natural behavior of systems whose action is generated through arbitration.

5. The Single-Source Condition

In a single-source system, action is not selected through negotiation between primary causes.

It is derived.

A proposed action is admissible if and only if it can be generated from the invariant without producing internal contradiction.

When derivation is not possible:

- action is suspended rather than arbitrated.

Coherence is therefore not achieved through conflict resolution but through the form of the generative structure itself.

6. Domain Neutrality

The single-source condition is not specific to any particular substrate or implementation.

It applies wherever intelligence must remain coherent across time and context, including:

- biological cognition
- artificial systems
- institutional and collective decision processes.

This paper does not treat these domains as identical. It identifies a shared structural requirement for the continuity of intelligent action.

7. Recurrence Across Domains of Coherent Agency

In domains concerned with sustained, non-contradictory action, a common structural move appears: the replacement of plural generative authority with a single invariant from which multiplicity can be derived without contradiction.

This recurrence is treated here as a convergence on a stability condition rather than as a shared doctrine or historical influence.

8. Behavioral Indicators

The single-source condition produces observable differences in system behavior.

A coherent intelligence:

- does not reverse its conclusions without new information
- does not require internal arbitration
- suspends action when derivation is not possible
- maintains continuity across domains.

An incoherent intelligence:

- balances primary directives against one another
- exhibits context-dependent core behavior
- produces internally incompatible outputs.

These indicators are empirically testable at the level of action.

9. Implications for Artificial Intelligence

Contemporary artificial systems are typically governed by plural generative structures in which multiple primary objectives must be balanced.

In such systems, alignment is pursued through:

- constraint layers
- post-hoc filtering
- reinforcement shaping.

Under the single-source condition, alignment becomes a different kind of problem.

It is no longer the optimization of competing objectives but the maintenance of admissibility under a causal invariant.

Safety is not externally imposed. It is a property of the generative form.

10. Conclusion

This paper has proposed that coherent intelligence requires a single non-contradictory generative causal source. Plural generative systems are intrinsically unstable because they must arbitrate between primary directives that cannot be reduced to one another. The single-source condition replaces arbitration with derivation and renders contradiction non-admissible.

This condition is domain-neutral and behaviorally observable. It is therefore presented as a necessary structural requirement for coherent intelligence.